

Photographs by ARUNACHAL TOURISM

Mechuka is slowly becoming a popular travel destination in Arunachal

Guests are warmly welcomed by locals all over the state



rich green hills and black soil, as we hike a kilometre up from the bridge. Men and women in their Galo finery regale us with a welcome dance, then an energetic cultural programme at the community centre at the top of the hill, as we endlessly refill our bamboo stalk cups with apong, the local wine. We stagger back down to the houses with our respective hosts, assisted by our cellphone flashlights and headlamps.

AN EVENING WITH REYOM ETE

The heart of Reyom Ete's house is the large, busy kitchen-cum-living-cum-dining room. Meat dries on great iron meshes hanging above two open fires. The family cooks us a full dinner from scratch—a chicken, green leafy vegetables, mountains of rice, beer and more apong. Arunachalis seem to find the sight of an empty glass in a guest's hand intolerable. An old gentleman totters in and settles by the fire, keeping up a lively monologue. "He's our neighbour," explains Reyom. Does he come over often? "Every day," says Reyom, his smile briefly tighter. I listen to the affaires de coeur of his teenage son and laugh and drink with the ladies till late. Many Arunachalis speak Hindi or English, or both, which allows communication not just with outsiders but also between tribes who share no common dialect.

In the morning, with a copper dawn shining off rice fields and gilding the hills, we get a full fresh-cooked breakfast of vegetables, rice and tea. Reyom gifts us each a 'hurgen', a ceremonial metal bell used in weddings, made by the much-respected local blacksmith. I look back from the bridge, wishing we could stay longer. Much of the road quality in Arunachal Pradesh puts Delhi to shame, with world-class highways and blacktop that makes driving an absolute joy—especially in the western part of the state. The road from